

Teen Spirit

There's no acne but everything else is spot-on in this booklette



A GIRL LIKE ME
by SWATI KAUSHAL
Penguin
Price: Rs 250
Pages: 339

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Unlike in the US where young adults have a terrifyingly aggressive sub-culture that threatens to spill over to the mainstream, teenagers in India are treated little better than add-ons, demographic misfits caught between the oh-so-sweet phase and the aren't-we-all-grown-up age, fit only to be wheeled out for their showpiece board exams and even showier foreign university admissions. If they are ever portrayed in pop culture, it is only by over-30 superstars trying to recapture cool (*Jo Jeeta Wohi Sikandar* and *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai* anyone?).

Which is why *A Girl Like Me* is such an unlikely little gem. In creating the plucky Anisha Rai, survivor of a transplant from Minnesota to Gurgaon, who misses her Abba-singing dad, Swati Kaushal has struck upon a phenomenon worthy of being rewarded with a sequel. Will Annie-Ani fall in love with her childhood buddy, the new age boy Kedar a.k.a. Keds? Will she have an angry showdown with her roguish much-too-old caddish boyfriend Kunal? Will she survive her teacher who thinks Maths is mental yoga? The prospect of an encore is delicious. Till then there is much to recommend Annie-Ani 101. From her uber competitive school with its extra sums for extra practice, extra tests for extra reading, and additional library hours for make-up study, all the way to the fumbling oral sex sessions in dimly-lit hostel rooms. Young adults will find a lot that is like their lives in the book—from the single-handed bloody combat with trigonometry to the super-busy, always travelling parents. As for older people, hey it's a chance to understand their eternally mysterious 16-year-olds. With a wince and a smile. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The 3 Mistakes of My Life	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
2. (4)	Sea of Poppies	Amitav Ghosh	Penguin
3. (2)	Brida	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins
4. (3)	A Prisoner of Birth	Jeffrey Archer	Pan Macmillan
5. (19)	A Case of Exploding Mangoes	Mohammed Hanif	Random House

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (2)	The Last Lecture	Randy Pausch and Jeffrey Zaslow	Hodder & Stoughton
3. (-)	AIDS Sutra: Untold Stories from India	William Dalrymple, Kiran Desai, Salman Rushdie et al	Random House
4. (20)	Empires of the Indus: The Story of a River	Alice Albinia	John Murray
5. (19)	Hot, Flat and Crowded: Why the World Needs a Green Revolution—and How we can Renew Our Global Future	Thomas L. Friedman	Allen Lane

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
8. (-)	An Atlas of Impossible Longing	Anuradha Roy	Picador
12. (5)	Unaccustomed Earth	Jhumpa Lahiri	Random House
13. (-)	The Palace of Illusions	Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni	Picador
14. (6)	The White Tiger	Aravind Adiga	HarperCollins
16. (12)	Six Suspects	Vikas Swarup	DoubleDay

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
7. (-)	India Express	Daniel Lak	Penguin
8. (15)	We are Like that Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India	Rama Bijapurkar	Penguin
9. (7)	Go Kiss The World	Subroto Bagchi	Penguin
11. (17)	Smoke and Mirrors	Pallavi Aiyar	Fourth Estate
12. (-)	Behenji: A Political Biography of Mayawati	Ajoy Bose	Penguin

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danaai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead